

Messages for Roli

In Memory of Deepak Kapur

April 2026

ThanhVu (Vu) Nguyen

Former PhD Student of Deepak's · Professor, George Mason University

It was a great shock when Roli told me about Deepak's passing on Saturday. We were in the middle of an NSF proposal submission, and Deepak had just sent me suggestions on Wednesday. Despite his deteriorating health, he was still very active in research and eager to learn new things, and his thinking was very sharp in his last days as it was when he was in his prime.

In the beginning of my PhD study at UNM, I was working on program repair using genetic programming, and we were quite successful in fixing real bugs. However, Deepak was skeptical about the lack of formal specification. He kept asking about the meaning of "correct" and "bug", which I could not provide, and this led him to question the work: "how can you fix what you don't understand?" Deepak transitioned me to his "rigorous" camp, and my PhD thesis is about dynamic invariant generation and more generally formal program analysis, which forms the basis of all my work since then.

Despite being a respected senior researcher, Deepak could be quite amusing and fun to be around. I always called him "Professor" (just Professor and not Professor Kapur) from the very beginning of my PhD. He found that amusing and started to call me "Professor" as well, which is how we addressed each other until I actually became a professor, at which point he started using my name. He also liked free food, and when he saw announcements from UNM events with food, he would send me to go and get some for him. I remember that once the Daily Lobo had an ad for a restaurant offering a heavy discount — \$1 for a taco/sandwich — and I grabbed 20-something newspapers from the Daily Lobo office, and we went there for lunch for almost a month. Clearly mischievous, but also a lot of fun.

When my first paper with him received the Distinguished Paper award at ICSE — the top conference in software engineering — he said "that tells him a lot about the quality of SE research." But that is how he was: brutally honest and never mincing his words, which of course could easily offend people. But if people could get past that, as I and many others who knew him well can attest, they would find that Deepak cared a lot for his colleagues, students, and especially about CS education and research — perhaps a bit too much, such that he got frustrated when he saw "junk" research or students lacking foundational knowledge. I should note that many CS faculty today feel exactly

the same way about the state of education in the age of AI and LLMs. The difference is that most of us are not as blunt as Deepak and therefore have much better RateMyProfessor ratings.

Deepak is the type of person that I simply do not believe could “retire” and would think about research until his last day. I have been working on neural network verification (NNV) in recent years, and Deepak was quite interested in this line of research and tried to learn about it — at the age of 73, knowing he had just a couple of years left! In fact, just a few weeks ago, I was describing to him my new paper on generating proofs to certify results of NNV tools, and he immediately observed that the resulting proofs can be used to modify the original networks and make them much smaller. I was quite excited about this idea and decided to invite him to be a co-PI on an NSF proposal I am submitting. His last message to me (Wed 4/8/2026 8:57PM) was about research. I imagine that in those last few days, he was still thinking about how to make NNV proof checking more efficient.

David Cyrluk

Former Mentee at GE R&D · Later PhD Researcher at Stanford/SRI

I heard from Dran about Deepak’s passing. I just want to take a few moments to convey my condolences and deep appreciation for the role Deepak had in my life.

He was my first mentor at GE’s R&D center at my first job out of college. In addition to his intelligence and hard work, he brought a commitment to me and my life that I felt and that made a real difference for me. He was also very blunt. I remember once, after sharing a very initial draft of a paper with him, his reaction was simply, “This sucks.” Not exactly what you want to hear from your supervisor, but appreciated in the end. He was straight with everyone he dealt with, and I knew that bluntness came from a place of caring and wanting me to do as well as I am capable of.

Another incident reflecting his straightforward style was when he noticed I wasn’t dating and didn’t have any girlfriends. At the time, I was extremely shy and nervous around women. In his blunt style, he just came up to me and asked me straight up about his not seeing me date. You can imagine how self-conscious and maybe embarrassed I might have felt, having a deficit just stated bluntly to me like that, but then again, it was an indication of Deepak’s deep caring about me, not just as a computer scientist and colleague, but as a complete person and friend.

One last memory: I was at Stanford and SRI working on my PhD thesis research, working on what would be a paper covering the last bit of research I needed to complete my PhD work, and while it was going to be a solo paper on my part, I remember talking back and forth with Deepak to help me make it as good as possible. He never stopped caring about me and being there for me.

I lost touch, as I did with many old friends, after my mental illness, but I was able to reconnect a little while ago, where I was able to share some of my writing and new plans. I am doing well now, and I have no doubt how happy Deepak would be to know that.

In my Jewish tradition, we say, “may their memory be a blessing” for those we have lost. Deepak was a real blessing in my life, especially in my formative years right out of school. As I remember all the ways he was there for me and what a special and unique person he was, his memory will be a continued blessing to me for the rest of my life.

With deep sorrow for your loss.

Shuang (Sean) Luan, PhD

Professor and Chair, Department of Computer Science, University of New Mexico

Deepak had a profound impact on UNM Computer Science. He joined the department in 1999 as Chair and helped transform it from primarily a teaching department into a research active one. To support faculty research, he significantly increased the number of TA lines, providing essential teaching support and serving as an important recruiting tool for top graduate students. These changes also helped reduce faculty teaching loads, allowing more time for research.

I joined in 2004 and directly benefited from these efforts. As Chair, Deepak recruited Darko Stefanovic (former long-time department chair), Jared Saia, Patrick Bridges (CARC director), Melanie Moses (too many roles to list from the Dean’s Office to the Provost Office and the state), and myself, all of whom are now full professors and form the backbone of the department today.

Deepak truly loved both research and teaching. He cared deeply about his students and was dedicated to supporting their growth, both academically and personally. In a way, it may be a blessing that he passed while doing what he loved throughout his life.

Deepak’s office and mine are just one door apart, and we were both usually early. For years, after dropping off my kids at school, I would walk down the empty hallway in Farris to my office. I would see his door ajar. I would say, “Good morning, Deepak!” and he would reply, “Good morning, Sir!” — even though he was far more senior than I am, he always responded that way.

We would often chat over coffee, and sometimes a snack, in the mornings, sharing stories. I know he hated Starbucks Caffè Verona. He was always curious about whatever new sweet treat I had brought in. He would accept them, though reluctantly, while still insisting that he really shouldn’t. He will be missed dearly by everyone in the department.

Gruia-Catalin Roman

Former Dean, University of New Mexico · Close Friend

I lost a dear friend and it is painful. He meant so much to me, both as a respected colleague and as a special human being. We first met when I came to UNM as Dean. Deepak was suspicious of my “brilliant” and “bold” initiatives based on a lifelong distrust of authority, well founded in his personal experiences. Later, we had offices close by and a deep friendship evolved. We shared similar values, we loved to analyze world affairs, we enjoyed retelling the story of our lives, and we encouraged each other to face challenges straight on. I loved our dinners together, especially those involving Roli’s wonderful cooking, and I appreciated his collection of great Scotches, which he generously offered for side-by-side tasting. He enjoyed movies and often recommended hard to watch traumatic stories about life in India.

Deepak loved both teaching and research. I think he was a perfectionist in both. I had the chance to see him teach and many a times we discussed pedagogy and the challenges students are facing. He showed care for the individual while demanding quality work; he accepted no shortcuts on his part and invested much effort to ensure an excellent learning experience, even when facing major health challenges. On the research side, he felt a deep obligation toward his graduate students and their future careers. He was a great mentor and rejected retirement out of a desire to see his last student graduate. Professionally, he was an excellent researcher who continued to maintain research funding until the very end. His dedication to intellectual inquiry and innovation were central to his identity and he could not envision a life without research.

I learned a lot from Deepak and will always think of him with affection. His passing is a great loss for our academic institution, his friends, and his family. Sarita and I love Roli and we are by her side in these difficult times.

Biju Mathew

Member, Indian Civil Liberties Union (ICWI)

I am so sorry to hear this news and I hope that Ila and you find the strength to live through this moment in all the stories and memories that you carry of Deepak.

I am devastated by this news. I had written to Deepak 3 or 4 weeks ago regarding some ICWI matters and when I didn’t hear back from him I had begun to get worried. And I even ended up calling Vinod and somewhere in that conversation asked gently if he knew how Deepak was doing. And I kept telling myself that I should keep the worry aside and that while there was a health

condition to be concerned about, it was something that we would all support Deepak through over the next many years.

I did not know Deepak very well even though he was part of our circles till 5 years ago when he joined ICWI and played a really important role in helping with the Bhima Koregaon forensic investigation. He became the person I would reach out to, to understand the technicalities, and he put me in touch with several people who have played a crucial role in that project. After that, from 2022 my conversations with him continued. Just recently, I heard from Bharat Rathore, an ICWI member who has built a very significant mentoring network called the Bahujans Scholar Network, that he was overjoyed at the news that Deepak had joined as a mentor and was helping a whole group of Bahujan CS students in India figure out career pathways. Deepak was actively thinking about caste when the initial ICWI work groups were being formed — he was the first one to volunteer for the anti-caste work-group. And when he moved to New York I was overjoyed, hoping to get to know him a lot better. But kya kare... that hope will never be realized. We will miss you, comrade.

Pedro, Maria Rosa, Dani and Marta

Collaborator and Friend · IMDEA Software Institute & Polytechnic University of Madrid

I am deeply sorry for the passing of your husband and father, Deepak Kapur. He was someone I cared about very much, and so did my family. I had the great privilege of working with him during several visits I made to UNM in Albuquerque, and also during his visits to Madrid, to the IMDEA Software Institute and the Polytechnic University of Madrid, over the years.

Dear Ila, I believe we have not had the chance to meet, but Deepak spoke to me about you often, always with pride and affection. I am truly sorry that my first message to you comes under such sad circumstances.

I am very grateful for your kindness and hospitality during all my visits to Albuquerque, some of them with my children, Dani and Marta. We deeply appreciated your invitations to your home and the meals we shared, and the warmth with which you always treated us. We hold very fond memories of the time we spent together. I am also grateful for the affection Deepak showed my family when he came to Madrid.

There are two matters I would like to mention whenever you feel ready. First, on the 7th, Deepak contacted me to ask for advice on transferring money from a Banco Santander account in Madrid to a dollar account in the United States. We had arranged to speak over Zoom on Saturday the 11th. When he did not reply to my last message, I became concerned and feared the worst. I can forward you our exchange of messages if you wish.

Second, Deepak and I had been working on a draft of a joint paper which we did not fully complete. I would very much like to finish it and submit it somewhere, with Deepak as first author. For me, this would be a way of honoring him and fulfilling a commitment I made to him. I would, of course, want to do this with your approval.

I am attaching two photos of Deepak that I took during our visit to Aranjuez in June 2014. Please know that you have friends here for anything you may need.

Anand Tandon

Friend and IIT Kanpur Alumnus · New Delhi

I am deeply saddened Deepak is not with us anymore. For unknown reason, good people leave us earlier than most.

In IIT Kanpur, Deepak and I did not know each other. We were not friends, or even acquaintances. He was in electrical engineering, and I in mechanical, so our paths seldom crossed. Yet, less than a decade ago, and without meeting personally, we became friends, thanks to a twist of fate.

Deepak was brutally honest, and passionate, about his politico-economic thoughts about India, and shared them openly in our IITK alumni email network. Hundreds of blind sycophants of the ruling party pounced on him around 2017 or so, for no decent reason, merely to rudely negate his views. I could not remain a silent bystander, so castigated all such in very strong and undiplomatic language. That one act somehow endeared me to him. Such was his graciousness, that from strangers one day we became — and remained — friends for years.

You could say we met for the first time when you and Deepak invited us to your home for dinner in 2021. You were gracious hosts, and my wife Sujata and I were overwhelmed by your hospitality. Deepak and I last exchanged messages on August 30, 2024, when he visited Delhi. I tried to advise him about his dental work, but he had to return to the US immediately, and we could not even meet.

Roli, please let me know if you or Ila come to Delhi or Lucknow again. Please count me as one of Deepak's friends in Delhi, and one eager to keep alive our friendship even after he has gone. Stay strong, because it allows us to relive the wonderful times with Deepak, and remember too how much he enriched our lives. Thank you, Deepak, for who you were, and how beautifully you touched all our lives.

S N Maheshwari (Sachin)

Professor, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, IIT Delhi

Sanjiva just told me about the passing away of Deepak. I am sad more than shocked. Every year when we met he seemed to have physically aged. But his conduct both physical and mental was so sharp that focus was never on the internal changes that were perhaps taking place. His involvements continued to be what they always had been. No letting off on any grounds. I met him first in the early 80s at the annual FST TCS conferences. What stood out was that unlike many others he always submitted his better papers at FST TCS. This was particularly impressive as there were not many among those who attended then with whom he could exchange ideas and/or collaborate. But he was always there. Looking back I would say he helped lay the foundation of automated theorem proving in India.

Over the last fifteen or twenty years my memories of Deepak are more of a social nature — time spent together on the Delhi campus on your annual visits. To me it was important that his visits to IIT be as smooth as they could be. Greatness had to be looked after particularly when the person wore it lightly.

I am sad for many reasons. I will miss his company, little discussions over sweet chai, and his aura. But your loss is much more profound. Only thing I will say to you is that rare persons like Deepak do not really go gently into night. They leave too much behind, not only in our memories but in the collective living of the community where his ideas will continue to challenge and inspire future generations for a long time.

Sue Susman

Life-Long Friend of Deepak and Roli · Monday, April 13, 2026

I've spoken to Roli but didn't offer formal condolences to either of you.

As Shantha wrote, your family has been intertwined with ours since before our kids were born. And Deepak coming back into our daily (or at least weekly) lives, with the move to New York, has been wonderful for us. We've gotten to march with him at No Kings, eat out (with Deepak alone and then with both Roli and Deepak), and to appreciate the new apartment.

So his loss is a particular blow — and I keep thinking Sekhar is talking to him on the phone.

I know that all three of you have led independent lives, but you always knew Deepak was there — and now he's not. So please accept a hug from me and Sekhar, who joins me in this note.

Thomas Wies

Professor, Department of Computer Science, NYU · Deepak's Collaborator During Sabbatical

Please accept my deepest condolences, also from my partner Ruzica Piskac, who knew Deepak for many years. We have been very saddened by this news.

Deepak was visiting me last summer and fall when he spent his sabbatical at NYU. Deepak told me not long ago that he and Roli bought an apartment in New York and that they were looking forward to spending more time in the city. He and I had plans to continue our collaboration once he had time to fully settle in New York.

I first met Deepak at a Dagstuhl seminar many years ago. Since I was attending the seminar locally from Saarbruecken, I was there by car and gave him a ride back at the end of the week. The car was fully packed with PhD students and Deepak did not mind at all. He was so kind and generous to us all. I always admired him — not only was he an exceptional scientist but also such a truly wonderful and kind person. It is a great loss. We will dearly miss him.

Sue Susman

Life-Long Friend of Deepak and Roli

In addition to Deepak's political understanding and activism, there was most recently Deepak the man who delighted in jazz in the parks, food vendors, and walking the streets of New York City. He lived alone here, teaching at NYU while Roli was helping her mother in Montreal, but he was always eager to explore. At a No Kings rally, he was amazed at the serendipity of meeting a colleague of mine who shared a detailed knowledge of leftist movements as we marched.

Like Vinod and Fely, Sekhar and I were waiting for him to get back to NY to take him to a new restaurant and to share pot luck at our kitchen table when he had a free evening.

Sekhar and I are very sad.

Felicitas (Fely) F. Santiago

Friend

It was with immense shock and profound sadness that we received the news of Deepak's passing. The thought of him and you finally settling into Manhattan was something we were so eagerly

anticipating, and it's truly difficult to reconcile this news, especially remembering how stable and well he seemed when I last saw him in your new condo.

Please accept our deepest and most heartfelt condolences, Roli, to you and your daughter during this incredibly difficult time. Our thoughts are with you as you navigate this unimaginable loss.

While we understand this is an overwhelming period, please know that whenever you feel ready, we would be grateful if you could share any details regarding memorial services or virtual rites, should you decide to hold them. We would very much like to pay our respects and be there to offer support in any way we can.

Natarajan Shankar

Computer Scientist, SRI International

I just came to know about Deepak's untimely passing. Deepak's friendship and guidance meant the world to me personally. His brilliance coupled with unmatched intellectual honesty and integrity made him a role model for several generations of researchers in automated reasoning. The world of computing owes a huge debt to Deepak for his stellar research contributions and his leadership. He will be deeply missed.

Please accept my heartfelt condolences and convey them to the rest of the family, and to his friends and colleagues.

Uma and Vijay Chandru

Friends · Vijay Chandru: Co-Founder & Director, Strand Life Sciences; Visiting Faculty, IISc and NCBS, Bangalore

We are so sorry to hear about Deepak's passing. We recall with fondness so many good times with Deepak and both of you. The last time we visited you in Albuquerque in 2022, Deepak shared his health challenges. Ila, Deepak was so proud of your achievements — you gave him great joy.

We will miss his friendship, wisdom and candour. Lots of love to both of you. Always remember that you have a home in Bangalore you can visit anytime.

Naijun Zhan

Collaborator · Chinese Academy of Sciences

I am so sad and shocked to hear this news. Please pass my wife's, my son's and my condolences to Roli and the family.

I will inform Deepak's Chinese friends immediately. Regarding his German friends, I know that he visited Viorica Sofronie-Stokkermans several times — she has since moved to Koblenz as a professor. He also has a former PhD student named Stefan Falke. I attended Jose's PhD defense organized by Deepak online on March 24, and saw him and Roli. Unbelievably, that was the last chance to see him, although he seemed weak at that moment.

Sorav Bansal

Faculty, Department of Computer Science, IIT Delhi

I am a faculty member in the Computer Science department of IIT Delhi, and I have had the pleasure of attending lectures by Prof. Deepak Kapur, and interacting with him, during his visits to our department. It was always a pleasure to listen to his clear and insightful talks — his enthusiasm for his subject was quite evident in the delivery of his talk. I always learned something by attending.

This is a loss for our research community, and for our department. My thoughts are with him and his family. Om shanti.

S. S. Ravi

Former Colleague, University at Albany · Now Part-Time, Biocomplexity Institute of UVA

I was shocked and saddened to hear about Deepak's passing. Please accept my heartfelt condolences. May God give you the necessary strength to bear this loss.

Deepak was an exceptional colleague at UAlbany. He brought a lot to the CS department. All the PhD students who graduated under his supervision have done very well in their careers. If I can help in any way, please don't hesitate to contact me.

Parvathi Chundi

Former Student · Associate Professor, University of Nebraska Omaha

I'm deeply saddened to hear about Prof. Deepak Kapur's passing. I feel truly fortunate to have learned so much from him and from you, which helped me have a fulfilling academic journey. I fondly remember the dinners at your house filled with lovely conversations. My heartfelt condolences to you, Ila, and the entire family. May his soul rest in peace.

Madhav Marathe

Former Student · Executive Director, Biocomplexity Institute, University of Virginia

I want to express our sincere condolences on the untimely demise of Deepak. Please take care of yourself and Roli. We are here to help so reach out as needed. Roli, Malvika and Aparna are very close to the apartment Deepak had told me about (they are on 48th and 3rd). I have communicated this to Subbu, Tushar, Venky, Sandeep and Parvathi and all convey their condolences as well. We all remember you fondly and as students deeply appreciate all he did for us. May his soul rest in peace.

Raza Mir

Friend

There will be time to grieve. But I want to take a minute to acknowledge the immensity of the man that has passed from among us. I was fortunate to have a few brief chats with Deepak since he moved to NYC. You all knew him a lot better, of course. But the quick way in which we connected speaks about a longer collective association that we could plug into. Roli, please accept my condolences, and pass them on to Ila as well.

M. S. Krishnamoorthy (Moorthy)

Professor Emeritus, Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute

I am deeply sorry to hear that Deepak Kapur passed away. I knew him from 1971 and he was an extremely smart person. He helped me a great deal at the early stages of my RPI career. He was prompt in replying to my sporadic email messages. My heartfelt condolences to you and Ila.

Achla Marathe

Friend

Dear Ila, please accept my sincere condolences. Your father was a true friend and a great mentor; he will be sincerely missed. May his soul rest in peace. If there is anything we can do for you and Roli, please do not hesitate to reach out. We are just a phone call away.

Chandru Murthi

Friend

I am shocked by this unexpected news. My sincere condolences. I never met Deepak; our mutual friend Sekhar introduced us and we had several email conversations sharing like medical issues.

Sanjiva Prasad

Professor, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, IIT Delhi

I am so sorry to hear of Deepak's passing away. Our deepest sympathies and sincerest condolences to you and to your daughter Ila. May you find the fortitude to bear the loss.

Vinod Mubayi

Friend

Really shocking news! I am in the airport waiting for my flight. Never thought it would happen so quickly. Heartfelt condolences.